

St Cyril of Alexandria
On Adoration, Book 1

ON ADORATION AND WORSHIP IN SPIRIT AND TRUTH
BOOK 1

*Concerning man's turning aside into baseness, and captivity to sin;
and likewise concerning the calling and return that come through
repentance, and the return to what is better.*

Cyril: To ask where you have come from would, I think, be superfluous. For you would answer—I know it well—that you made no prior arrangement, having come from home and in our usual way.

Palladius: True.

Cyril: But tell me, what is this in your hands?

Palladius: The Gospel, written by Matthew and John.

Cyril: Do you think it must be carried about just anywhere and by anyone? For surely you would not, going from door to door, be studying it, O Palladius. The labors devoted to this are rather sweet at home and in quiet study.

Palladius: You speak well. And having come to confer with you, I bring the sacred scroll; for after countless labors I still cannot grasp what our Lord Jesus Christ declares in Matthew, saying, “Do not think that I have come to abolish the law or the prophets. I have not come to abolish but to fulfill. For truly I say to you, until heaven and earth pass away, not one jot or one tittle will in any way pass from

the law until all is accomplished.” (Matthew 5:17-18) And in the Gospel according to John, to the woman from Samaria: “Believe me, woman, the hour is coming when you will neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem worship the Father. You worship what you do not know; we worship what we know, that salvation is from the Jews. But the hour is coming, and now is, when the true worshippers will worship the Father in spirit and truth. For the Father seeks such to worship him. God is a Spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.” (John 4:21-24)

Cyril: Well then, what is this steep and arduous matter that seems so to you, at least in these things? And what is the deep and hard-to-reach point? Explain it to me who am asking.

Palladius: We are accustomed to departing from the older ways, and the sacred word commands us that righteousness in the Law must cease. And Paul said to those who pursue this even after faith: “You have fallen away from Christ, you who are justified by the Law; you have fallen away from grace. For we receive the hope of righteousness through faith through the Spirit.” (Galatians 5:4-5) But concerning the way of life according to the Law, who indeed showed us, as things to boast of on his own account, bright and splendid achievements, he again says: “What things were gain to me, I have made these a loss for Christ. But I count all things loss for the excellence of the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ, for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and count them but rubbish, that I may gain Christ, and be found in him, not having my own righteousness, which is of the law, but that which is through faith in Christ, the righteousness which is of God.” (Philippians

3:7-9) He clearly affirmed that the ancient commandment is not blameless. For this very reason, he says, the new one through Christ, that is, the gospel, has been brought in usefully for us in place of that. And he writes thus: “For annulment comes of the preceding commandment, because of its weakness and uselessness. For the Law perfected nothing, but the introduction of a better hope, through which we draw near to God.” (Hebrews 7:18-19) And again: “For if that first had been blameless, no place would have been sought for a second.” (Hebrews 8:7) For, reproaching them, he says, “The days are coming, says the Lord, that I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel, and with the house of Judah, not according to the covenant that I made with their fathers in the day that I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt; because they did not continue in my covenant, so I disregarded them, says the Lord. For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, says the Lord: I will put my laws into their mind, and I will write them in their hearts.” (Hebrews 8:8-12) And especially, as one who understands and interprets the name of newness: “In saying,” he says, “new, he has made the first old; for what is becoming old and aging is near to vanishing.” (Hebrews 8:13) If then the Law has perfected nothing, and there has been annulment of the ancient commandment and introduction of the second, making us akin to God, why does the Savior say, “I have not come to destroy the law, but to fulfill it?” (Matthew 5:17) and that, “it is fitting that we worship God and the Father in spirit and truth?” (John 4:23-24) For this, I think, signifies that we must cease from the customs and the worship according to the Law.

Cyril: It is as if you have set out on a broad sea of questions! For what mind would suffice to contemplate brilliantly theories so subtle—as, through what was divinely established of old by all-wise Moses, to show us the new Scripture as a kind of sister and neighbor, proceeding through the same matters, and the life in Christ as not greatly separated from the legal way of life—if the things prescribed for the ancients are not brought to spiritual contemplation? For the law is a type and a shadow, and the formation of piety is still as in labor pains, having the beauty of truth hidden within itself. Or will you not say that it is as I have said?

Palladius: Very much so. But who could give an explanation of this? Or what is the manner of living according to the Gospel, while still seeming to be derived from the ancient commandment and thinking to fulfill what was given through Moses?

Cyril: The discourse is not simple, as one might suppose; but virtue, I think, is a thing both many-branched and multiform; and the glories of life in Christ are richly embroidered through very great good works among us. And indeed the glorious David, in the forty-fourth psalm, presents to Christ the Church, a pure virgin, in the role of a queen, and sets upon her a gold-adorned and variegated robe, saying thus: “The queen stood at your right hand, clothed in gilded and varied clothing.” (Psalm 44:10) The gold-adorned aspect, I would say, signifies what is honorable and splendid; and the variegated aspect clearly indicates the many-formed character of virtue. For the Church is most beautiful, having a spiritual adornment not visible to the eyes of the flesh, but to the mind within and the heart—the Jew understood in secret—displaying through

very many adornments among us a natural and exceptional grace. For as the blessed Paul writes: “For he is not a Jew who is one outwardly, nor is circumcision that which is outward in the flesh, but he is a Jew who is one inwardly, and circumcision is that of the heart, in the Spirit not in the letter, where the praise is not from men, but from God.” (Romans 2:28-29)

Palladius: Tell me, then: since circumcision in the Spirit has been brought in, and the sacrifices according to the law have been overthrown, and have no place in our way of life among us, does it not seem plausible to say that Christ declared, “I did not come to abolish the law, but to fulfill it?” (Matthew 5:17) Or if it is not so, would it not, I think, hinder us as well—that we have nothing left but to honor the God of all with ox-sacrifices and incense, yet offer him turtledoves and doves; and if anything else besides is customary among the ancients, that we ourselves should also be pressed to fulfill it?

Cyril: And indeed, O friend, you push far aside much of what is fitting; for you think the law has been overthrown, as though it profited nothing and its exposition of all necessary things were entirely useless—not that it has rather been transformed into a demonstration of the truth—although the blessed Paul writes: “Do we then nullify the law through faith? Certainly not! Rather we uphold the law.” (Romans 3:31) For the law acts as pedagogue and leads well to the mystery in Christ. We say that what was divinely ordained of old through Moses for the ancients are the rudiments of the beginning of the oracles of God. But if we push aside the pedagogue, who will still convey us to the mystery of Christ? And if

we refuse to learn the rudiments of the beginning of the oracles of God, how could we still go forward, or from where could we arrive at the end? For is not Christ, according to the Scriptures, the fulfillment of the law and the prophets?

Palladius: Yes.

Cyril: For it is written thus. And the fulfillment of the law and prophets would be, I think, in him—for everyone who beholds and turns toward both prophetic and legal divine ordinance. Therefore he said, putting the disobedience of the Jews to shame: “Do not think that I will accuse you to the Father. There is one who accuses you: Moses, in whom you have set your hope. For if you believed Moses, you would believe me; for he wrote concerning me. But if you do not believe his writings, how will you believe my words?” (John 5:45-47) If then one should say that he came by no means to abolish the law but rather to fulfill it, he does not intend the complete overthrow of what was ordained of old, but rather a transformation, as it were—and, so to speak, a re-engraving of what was in types toward the truth.

Palladius: You have said rightly.

Cyril: And indeed such a thing ought to have been done by Christ. Those skilled in the art of panel-painting and drafting do not immediately begin by painting the finished and fully perfected form on their works; rather, they first sketch very well in an initial and less beautiful color, and perhaps bring out the forms beforehand in still fainter tones if they choose, then overlay them with shading—the shape most fitting and suitable to each—and so

transfer the types from outline into visible form, incomparably better than what was at the beginning. Or is it not so?

Palladius: I say so myself.

Cyril: But those who practice the craft of bronze-casting, if they wish to cast a statue, first shape an inert wax model; then, melting it with fire, they pour on the bronze, and thus bring the work to a well-formed beauty. Yet when the shadows of the varied multiplicity of colors are cast upon it—and indeed when the bronze melts away what came from the wax—it might seem briefly as though the first and initial shapes had been set aside and overthrown. But the matter is not really so by nature. For the coppersmith and the painter would say, speaking truly: We have not destroyed the shadows; we have not sent the types into complete uselessness, but rather we have fulfilled them. For what was to be seen still in shadows and types, both more hidden and less beautiful, has advanced to what is better and more manifest.

Palladius: You have spoken well.

Cyril: And if anyone should choose to examine diligently the holy and God-breathed Scripture, he will know for certain that what I say is true. For Moses placed a veil over his face, so that the children of Israel could not look intently at his face, as it is written. (Exodus 34:33-35)

Palladius: And what does this mean?

Cyril: For the minds of the Jews, being still duller, could somehow endure the outwardly manifest things of the law—I mean again

those things that are through the letter alone; but the hidden inward things were completely unbearable and utterly unapproachable, and, so to speak, the true face of the meanings. Therefore the inspired Paul also writes to us: “For until this day the same veil remains at the reading of the Old Testament, not unveiled, because it is abolished in Christ. But until this day, when Moses is read, a veil lies upon their heart.” (2 Corinthians 3:14-15) But let the case of the Jews stand here. “We all, with unveiled face,” he says, “beholding as in a mirror the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory, just as from the Lord who is the Spirit.” (2 Corinthians 3:16-18) For just as those who look in a mirror see an image and type of the truth, and would fix their gaze on that rather than on the truth itself, so too, I think, those who desire to see the beauty of life in Christ, using the law as a mirror, would accomplish what they desire as well as possible. For by transforming the same image of things into truth, they will know clearly what seems most especially pleasing to God.

Palladius: What then might the reason be—that in ancient times the new and Evangelical revelation was not given from the beginning, but rather types and shadows were legislated?

Cyril: The precise plan of the dispensation, and how these things were to be ordered—according to what is truer—must piously be entrusted to the all-knowing God. But our reasonings, not knowing that we lack conceptions of good things, somehow lead us even to moderate knowledge, or perhaps to making the pretext of dispensation seem like knowledge. We say, therefore, that much pedagogy and a certain childlike manner of upbringing were needed

for those redeemed from Egypt. For they were still dull and altogether susceptible to every most discordant thing. With a love of the flesh wholly hard to wash away, weakened by it, and entangled in passions hard to escape, it was somehow still beyond their reach and they were not ready to receive that they could immediately spring up to what is exceedingly refined—as if to take up again a way of life so bright and surpassing nature as to walk upon the earth yet hold one's citizenship in heaven, as it is written. (Philippians 3:20) For is not solid food for the perfect, while milk is more fitting for those still infants? (Hebrews 5:14)

Palladius: Quite so.

Cyril: There was need therefore of pedagogy in types, while they were still infants, and, so to speak, of a more tender upbringing—not of the word that ordains toward perfection and can bring one to full maturity. But being so light-minded and of little understanding, and easy prey to every passion, the Israelites would have been overcome; for if a strict trial of their conduct and actions had been applied among them, I think they would not even have been deemed worthy of a shadow. And Moses showed this. For when God gave the command, he himself ascended the mountain to receive the law. But they immediately slipped into apostasy. For they had made a calf, and the wretches had dared to say: “These are your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt.” (Exodus 32:4) At such terrible lightness of mind Moses was grieved, and he shattered the tablets on which the law was written—judging those whose mind was so deranged not even worthy of shadow or types, or even of any pedagogy from above, since they forgot the marvels

accomplished for them through divine power, and again assigned worship to a calf, and called to remembrance the worship practiced in Egypt. Yet on stone tablets the law was then sketched in shadow for the ancients by the finger of God, as it is written. (Exodus 31:18) Those things were a type of us who are believed to have come into being in Christ. For the God who is Lord of all inscribes in us, as it were, the knowledge of his own will, using the Son as a reed in the Spirit. For David named him thus, saying: “My tongue is the pen of a ready scribe.” (Psalm 44:2) For the Father's reed—that is, the Son—has engraved on all hearts the knowledge of every good, as by a finger of God, using both the Father's finger and his own Spirit. For he named the Spirit of God a finger, saying at one time, “If I cast out demons by the Spirit of God,” and at another, “If I cast out demons by the finger of God.” (Matthew 12:28; Luke 11:20) And Paul also called us a spiritual letter, saying: “You are our letter, written in our hearts, known and read by all men, being made manifest that you are a letter of God ministered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets that are hearts of flesh.” (2 Corinthians 3:2-3)

Palladius: But that the things according to the law are types and shadows—I too would say so; be well assured of it. Come then, applying our mind subtly and exactly to those things foretold in type, let us inquire very diligently into the beauty of truth. For thus the mystery of worship in the Spirit would no longer be obscure to anyone.

Cyril: And indeed, O noble one, I have very reasonably shuddered at this, and I am most exceedingly reluctant toward it. For I think that

for men of our time things whose contemplation is so sprawling and overstretched are perhaps not easily grasped. Yet I think one must say to one who examines the depth of the theorems in the law: “Who is wise, and he will understand these things? and discerning, and he will know them?” (Hosea 14:9)

Palladius: The matter is no easy one, O friend. But “Ask,” Christ says, “and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you.” (Matthew 7:7)

Cyril: We must therefore set out to what is needed, zealously to seek what leads to benefit; and indeed let us stretch forth supplication, saying: “Open my eyes, and I will behold wondrous things out of your law.” (Psalm 118:18) But we must, as it seems, before other things speak of the turning aside of man into baseness, and of slavery and captivity under the enemy of all, and in what way these things are carried out among us and within us. We must also add how one ought to turn away from evil, shake off the yoke of slavery to him, and spring back again toward what was in the beginning, with God preserving and helping. For with us proceeding on this fitting path of discourse, the rest too would be fitting, I think.

Palladius: You think most rightly.

Cyril: For to be able to bear fruit to God and offer spiritual sacrifices—that is, to be courageous, to be approved, and to desire to accomplish virtue—would surely not be fitting for those so given over to slavery and the compulsion of passions, but rather for those whose mind is already somewhat sobering toward freedom, and for whom it is not left unpracticed to shake off the yoke of the devil's

covetousness.

Palladius: I agree, for you understand correctly.

Cyril: And indeed let us also say that man was made in the beginning, still having his mind somehow above sin and passions, yet not wholly incapable of being deflected to whatever he might choose. For it seemed right to God, the supreme Craftsman of all things, to put into his hands the reins of his own wills, and to allow him to act as seems good with self-directed impulses. For virtue had to be voluntary, and not as though compelled by necessity, nor yet unwaveringly fixed by the laws of nature; for that would belong to the supreme essence and transcendence of all. But since the living creature was fashioned by God the Craftsman through the principles of his own nature, he immediately enriched him with likeness to himself. For the image of the divine nature was engraved on him, when the Holy Spirit was breathed into him. For that Spirit is the breath of life, since God is by nature life.

Palladius: Then did the divine Spirit become man's soul?

Cyril: And how is it not altogether absurd to think this way? For if the Spirit were unchangeable, the soul too would have remained unchanged; but now it is changeable. Yet the Spirit is in no way changeable. Or if it were subject to change, would the blemish run back upon the divine nature itself—for it is the Spirit of God and the Father, and indeed also of the Son, proceeding essentially from both (οὐσιωδῶς ἐξ ἀμφοῖν), that is, poured forth from the Father through the Son (ἐκ Πατρὸς δι' Υἱοῦ προχέομενον)? It is therefore ignorant to think that the Spirit was transformed into a soul and passed over

into human nature. Rather, what was molded was ensouled by ineffable power, and was immediately adorned by the gift of the Spirit. For otherwise the divine image in us could not be enriched.

Palladius: You have spoken well.

Cyril: God therefore, having adorned his handiwork, granted him life in paradise. But since the one thus beautified and crowned with the abundance of goods from above had to be kept from being easily carried toward arrogance, ignorant of his servitude—and since there is a measure even for household servants (for what is too expansive leads to laxity, and what is immoderately free leads to haughty and accursed passion)—a law of self-control was given him as a means of not ignoring the Master, so that through it he might always be called to remembrance of the one who commands with authority, and might clearly know that he is subject to the ordinances of the Ruler. But that impious and God-hating beast did not rest.

Palladius: You would say, I suppose, that Satan—who was hurled down like lightning from the heavenly vaults—was childishly sick with the desire to be God, and while declaring things beyond his own nature, was only fantasizing.

Cyril: You reason well. For being the inventor of envy and sin, and their father, he did not wish to remain inactive regarding the creature on earth, that is, man. Then, having approached with deceit and trickery, he brought him to disobedience, using the woman as an instrument of cunning. For always in some way the pleasures that are with us and in us shake us toward the unseemly—that is, into sin; and the woman is the type of pleasure; and by the blandishments

that come from pleasures the mind is often brought to what it does not will. What therefore is seen to have happened in Adam, as in a dense mass of events and perceptibly, one would also observe being fulfilled in each of us, both intellectually and in hidden fashion. For pleasure rising beforehand beguiles the mind, and little by little draws it toward thinking at last that transgression of the divine law is nothing at all. And the disciple of Christ will confirm it, saying: “Let no one when tempted say, ‘I am tempted by God.’ For God cannot be tempted by evil, and he himself tempts no one. But each one is tempted when he is drawn away and enticed by his own desire. Then desire, when it has conceived, gives birth to sin; and sin, when it is full-grown, brings forth death.” (James 1:13-15)

Palladius: The argument is unerring.

Cyril: Having therefore cast off the grace from God, and already stripped of the goods of the beginning, human nature was sent out from the paradise of delight; and immediately it was transformed toward the unseemly, and having fallen into corruption within, was then laid bare.

Palladius: Necessarily. For I think that lack of the gifts from God is nothing other than a falling away from all good. Human nature would also very easily be weakened into deflection toward every improper thing, unless the grace of the Savior upheld it toward virtue, enriching it with good things from above and from itself.

Cyril: You have spoken well. For I would most reasonably agree. For the living bread, that is, the word of God, nourishes the spiritual soul unto strength. For it is written: “And bread strengthens the heart

of man.” (Psalm 103:15) It also frees from slavery and passions, and richly adorns with the boast of freedom. But when God as it were has drawn back his hand and does not distribute provision to us in these matters, of necessity we somehow fall into evils even against our will, slip away from all virtue, and undergo as it were the yoke of another, coming to such evils and covetousness as to be on the verge of losing even the understanding that served us in every good thing and dwelt with us, so that the heart of the sufferer appears wholly bereft of wisdom according to God—having prostituted itself to Satan and having easily submitted to the insults and debaucheries worked by him.

Palladius: Will you demonstrate how, or will you allow us to be borne along by mere reasoning?

Cyril: Not at all. For I would demonstrate as well as I can what happened to the ancients, artfully shaping them into types of the spiritual realities. For in subtle contemplation, vivid and very clear images would be given us of things that are significant both in perception and in visible appearance. It is written therefore concerning the forefather Abraham: “And there was a famine in the land, and Abraham went down to Egypt to sojourn there, because the famine was severe in the land.” (Genesis 12:10) For leaving the land dear to him and that bore him, he was turning toward another that God had shown him. “Go forth,” he says, “from your land and from your kindred, and come to the land that I will show you.” But when the famine was pressing down and bringing quite inescapable harm, he was compelled against his will to look to Egypt. And he did not settle there, but rather sojourned in it.

Palladius: What then does this mean?

Cyril: It shapes for us the excellent contemplation of the more hidden realities.

Palladius: In what way?

Cyril: Reproving the disobedience of the Jews, God said somewhere: “Behold, I bring a famine upon the land—not a famine of bread, nor a thirst for water, but a famine of hearing the word of the Lord. And from east to west they shall run about seeking the word of the Lord, and they shall not find it.” (Amos 8:11-12) Is it not then, O friend, that those overwhelmed by such famine, who have fallen from the provision that holds sway toward virtue and lack the food from heaven and above, are somehow wholly compelled to make the mind migrate and become as a fugitive, turning afterward to baser things, and—like one driven from his own land of strength in virtue—to descend into another state and will, no longer under God but subject rather to diabolical scepters? For the father and king of sin, I think, who first brought it into the world, is he of whom one would very reasonably accept Pharaoh, ruler of the Egyptians, as image and type. Among them the darkness of going astray was very deep, and no form of wickedness was wholly unpracticed.

Palladius: And what grieved the blessed Abraham about his perhaps settling in the land of the Egyptians?

Cyril: Largely, at any rate, to that extent. For he was borne through every evil by only a little. You would learn this also easily from holy Scripture saying: “And it came to pass when Abram entered into

Egypt, the Egyptians saw the woman, that she was very fair; and the princes of Pharaoh saw her, and commended her to Pharaoh, and brought her into Pharaoh's house.” (Genesis 12:14-15) Consider then, O friend, that his wife had almost perished for him.

Palladius: How painful the matter is, and sufficient to cause grief.

Cyril: And indeed this will happen to us ourselves in spiritual understanding. For whenever one slips away from his homeland, as it were his own, and from his customary and most beloved good order and virtue, and settles toward worse things and comes under diabolical scepters, the evil and hostile powers spring up everywhere and in every way and plot terribly; and even if they see someone born under them capable of a mind not without decency, they strive to secure him for their own teacher and subject him to his sowings, so that he bears fruit no longer to God but rather to Satan. “For his foods,” as it is written, “are choice;” and they bewitch, as it were, the mind that has been captured and has slipped, so that, not looking much toward freedom, it might depart from the servitude under them. They sometimes preserve earthly pleasures, and, so to speak, heap worthless merriment upon us, just as indeed the rulers of the Egyptians also did—when they nearly destroyed the blessed Abraham's wife, overwhelming him, as it were, with honors and the offering of gifts, wishing to carry away his great grief. For it is written that “And they treated Abraham well for her sake”—clearly meaning Sarah—“and there were given to him flocks and herds, and donkeys, and male servants and female servants, and mules, and camels.” (Genesis 12:16) For Satan, overreaching us at the most opportune moments and, as it were, freely depriving us of offspring

and good fruitfulness, subjects the noble mind through covetousness by his own insults and debaucheries, and binds it with earthly delight. And he once ran to such madness as even to put Christ to the test. “For leading him up,” it says, “the devil showed him all the kingdoms of the inhabited world in a moment of time, and the devil said to him: To you I will give all this authority and their glory, for it has been delivered to me, and to whomever I will I give it. You therefore, if you worship before me, all shall be yours.” (Luke 4:5-7)

Palladius: That is correct. But answer me who ask: what benefit, or rather what help, would there be for those who have suffered?

Cyril: God, O noble one, and the grace from him do not allow the weakened mind to remain under diabolical feet forever, but shield and rescue the one who can in no way defend himself. You would see, if you wished, this very thing having happened also in the case of the forefather Abraham. For when the righteous man had given up and was wholly unable to act, God came between, and freed the woman from Egyptian licentiousness. “For the Lord afflicted Pharaoh with great and evil punishments, and his house, because of Sarah, Abraham's wife.” (Genesis 12:17) And thus he restored his wife, who dwelt with the righteous man, scarcely free from outrage. God therefore and alone would rescue the captured mind from the devil's hand and turn it back to the good order it had in the beginning.

Palladius: For by lack of the good things from above, being thrust downward, we sometimes descend toward shameful and abominable things.

Cyril: So I say.

Palladius: But it is altogether fitting somehow for the God who loves the good, that he should not allow us to fall into any such things.

Cyril: This is most especially fitting for God, and also desirable, O friend; for he would be least good, and not very a lover of virtue, if he did not have this aim toward us. But we ourselves are responsible for our suffering, provoking the Lord of all to wrath; for he permits thus toward a weak and unmanly mind. Or do you not hear one crying through a holy prophet: “Behold, I send upon this people weakness, and in it fathers and sons shall grow weak; neighbor and his neighbor shall perish.” (Jeremiah 6:21) And concerning some, the wisest Paul also writes: “And as they did not see fit to acknowledge God, God gave them up to a reprobate mind, to do what is not fitting.” (Romans 1:28) And the venerable Isaiah states this even more plainly, speaking as from the person of the sons of Israel, that is, of those who slipped into sin: “Behold, you were angry, and we sinned.” (Isaiah 64:5)

Palladius: Tell me then: when we are negligent toward what is fitting and are taken captive by sins, shall we cast the blame on God and accuse him of wrath, as though we had sinned because of that?

Cyril: We shall certainly not accuse God—that would be madness. But in saying, “You were angry, and we sinned,” (Isaiah 64:5) we mean something like this: as if, unless we have your gracious restraint, O Master, nothing holds us back—we are tyrannized by sin through the weakness of our nature, and are altogether entangled in every evil.

Palladius: I understand what you say.

Cyril: Therefore, stripped of both care and sparing from above, and of extreme exhaustion, and paying the penalty for unrestrained turnings toward the base, we are weak and easily overcome—and why should we not show ourselves weakened by all such things? Here, then, for you to behold these things clearly, in the words of Jeremiah you meet. For the wild multitude of the Jews, though very richly indulging and flourishing in the honors from God, and having prevailed over all their enemies, had advanced perhaps to the very height of human glory, yet practiced hard and unbreakable disobedience. Almost claiming to be strong in Moses' commandments, and counting the oracles almost wholly unworthy of mention, they were borne with unchecked rush to destruction and ruin. For under oak, poplar, and shady tree, according to the prophet's voice, they built altars; and in the most wooded groves they established precincts for demons, and with sacrifices, incense, and all else thought fit to honor as gods and saviors the things fashioned by their own hands—what of such things would they not blush to name? And they descended to such folly as to make unholy child-murders a matter of boasting, and to think they were thus offering the fattest sacrifice. Nor did Israel's impiety stop at this. Always adding to their daring an unbridled departure toward every improper thing, they not moderately provoked wrath upon themselves, though the lawgiver was good. But when they vigorously shook off their service to him, he permitted them also to be overreached by their enemies and borne toward slavish service already necessary under the Chaldeans and Babylonians. For those who had left their homes came, having enslaved them and burned

the holy and renowned city; and the besieged seemed scarcely to ask the prophet Jeremiah where their evil would end for them. “And Jeremiah said,” it says, “Thus shall you say to Zedekiah: Thus says the Lord: Behold, I turn the weapons of war with which you fight against the Chaldeans who have shut you in outside the walls, into the midst of this city. And I myself will fight against you with outstretched hand and mighty arm, with great anger and wrath. And I will strike all who dwell in this city, both man and beast, with a great plague, and they shall die.” Then after other things: “And to the people you shall say: Thus says the Lord: Behold, I set before you the way of life and the way of death. He who remains in this city shall die by sword and famine; and he who goes out to surrender to the Chaldeans who besiege you shall live, and his soul shall be as spoil, and he shall live. For I have set my face against this city for evil and not for good; and it shall be delivered into the hand of the king of Babylon, and he shall burn it with fire.” (Jeremiah 21:4-10) Understand, then, that by grieving God with our former honors, we wretches shall be unable to resist the strength of our enemies; and with divine wrath lying upon us and rushing down, we shall be slaves instead of free, and shall live a life dishonored and wretched.

Palladius: You have spoken well.

Cyril: For God's law leads the tender and gentle soul to blameless citizenship, and becomes like a lamp to each for the showing forth of what is useful and necessary; and mastered by reverence toward it, one would live, I think, not without distinction, and as it were inhabit a holy city, established in virtue and advanced in piety. But if someone should choose, like some blooming and well-wooded

forest, to plunge readily into worldly pleasures, and to dwell fondly in life's delights, and as it were to welcome into mind and heart a swarm of idols—the manifold pleasure—and to offer incense to demons with the fruits of his zeal, then indeed he would very reasonably slip from the sparing from above, and very ready prey would be set before those who wish to capture him. Having been driven out, as it were, from the holy city of his original good order, he will depart as if under a necessary yoke toward what seems good to those in power, and will be far from God according to the manner of his disposition, enduring deportation to Babylon—that is, the regions beyond the borders of the holy land, in which God is known and his name is great. Therefore those who endured such harsh pain, and fell into the hands of their enemies, and could not bear life among them as slavish and servile, cried out: “By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when we remembered Zion.” (Psalm 136:1) For the human mind, I think, is somehow afflicted by such things.

Palladius: What then do you mean?

Cyril: For he is always somehow slack and sprawled out in desire for the good things in his hands, yet he does not much yearn for those over which he would have authority. But if there should be a summons to the other course, and he should cease being overcome by the splendid things he possesses, then only with difficulty does he perceive, once he has suffered, what he ought to have warded off with all his strength—and he does not allow experience to forestall the attack by cutting it off beforehand.

Palladius: True.

Cyril: It is necessary, then, and wise—and among the most advantageous things—to forestall wicked deeds and the onset of unwilling slavery, and to try swiftly to turn aside from whatever, if put to the test, would leave us in utter misery.

Palladius: That is so.

Cyril: And if indeed from divine wrath the yoke of necessary slavery were brought upon us, and indeed also the having to settle into a reprobate mind, to resist would not be easy. Yet I would say it would be useful—even if only to remember from what state into what we have been turned aside, and bitterly to lament the neglect and the scarcity of help from above: “For godly sorrow produces repentance unto salvation without regret.” (2 Corinthians 7:10) But since divine wrath is not hanging over us, but it is in our power to choose and do what seems good, and we still have both inclinations—toward the base, I mean, and toward the good—somehow relaxed and wholly unconstrained, we must manfully reject the softening that comes through baseness; and I think we must shake off loving pleasures among enemies, and doing what lies at the enemies' hand—those who are said to rule this age. And even if some share of worldly prosperity should come—I mean prosperity valued in the world—it turns altogether to a shameful and unseemly end.

Palladius: What do you mean by that?

Cyril: Do you wish that we speak, taking examples from ancient times?

Palladius: By all means.

Cyril: With famine consuming those throughout, so to speak, the whole land, it seemed fitting for those descended from Jacob to go down to the Egyptians. They were young men, about ten in number, and the purpose of their journey abroad was to buy provisions—and there was nothing else. And when they had come to this point and were at last recognized as brothers, with Joseph then dispensing grain and governing Egypt, Pharaoh welcomed what was done toward them: “And Pharaoh said to Joseph, ‘Say to your brothers: Do this—fill your sacks, and go to the land of Canaan; and take your father and your possessions, and come to me, and I will give you all the good things of Egypt, and you shall eat the fat of the land. And you, command them to take wagons from the land of Egypt for your little ones and your wives; bring your father and come, and do not regret leaving your household goods behind; for all the good things of Egypt shall be yours.’” (Genesis 45:17-20) The ruler of Egypt promised them ample rest and luxury to satisfy them, and he even provided wagons, I think to soften the journey for those hesitating to go down. But they went down at once with all their households, having somehow—I know not how—preferred the temporary enjoyment of provisions to the land and country given by God; for far better and superior it was to inhabit that land, even if the matter were secured with little hardship. When they came to Egypt, they perhaps thought they would also escape the hardships at home, to which even the sense of immediate pleasures was somehow sweet to them. But as time wore on, the inglorious yoke of slavery crept upon them—the multitude noble and free from their fathers from above. Therefore, if along with worldly prosperity there should come falling into shameful things, it must be refused, my friend—if

freedom is for us in principle, for slavish disposition and mindset are abhorrent and odious.

Palladius: You have spoken well.

Cyril: But what—shall we not also mention that, as it seems to me, coupling no small benefit with what has just been said to us?

Palladius: What exactly do you mean?

Cyril: Rabshakeh the Babylonian, general of the Assyrians, once drew along a body of guards beyond number, and came to besiege—indeed, supposing he would quite effortlessly capture the entire holy city from its foundations. Then he was brandishing his weapons, which were not unpracticed but very familiar to him, with reviling speech against God. And saying countless taunting words, he was also proclaiming finally to those inhabiting the holy city: “Thus says the king of Assyria: If you wish to be blessed, go to me, and let each eat of his own vine and his own fig trees, and drink water from your cistern, until I come and take you to a land like your land, a land of grain and wine and bread and vineyards.” (2 Kings 18:31) See, then, that he too promises luxury and delight upon vine and fig; and he adds, “And drink water from your cistern.”

Palladius: But what would these things signify, if they were directed toward spiritual contemplation?

Cyril: In a twofold manner, I think, the power of baseness in us is carried out. For either by pleasures from outside, or by those innate and within us, we are persuaded to revel both by ourselves and also by others; and having slipped toward anything most offensive, those

prone to sin would be overcome. The Savior's disciple would show us this too as true, saying as follows: "For all that is in the world—the lust of the flesh, and the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life." (1 John 2:16) For the lust of the flesh, innate and rooted and abiding in us ourselves, Paul the divine named for us as sin's law, dwelling in the members of the flesh. And pleasures and delights from outside and adopted—those through the eyes. For things from wealth are admired through the eyes, and also fine clothing, and whatever things some might cling to as having sweetest enjoyment, granting them no base judgment. So then, vine and fig tree would together be a type of pleasure and luxury from outside and adopted, cleverly showing the temporary and easily destroyed character of worldly matters, and along with this the sweetness joined to what customarily darkens. For all worldly luxury has sweet immediate participation, but it greatly darkens and terribly intoxicates the one who has received it. And the cistern is an image of the innate movements within us. For these are not adopted from outside as those are, but spring forth as within us, bubbling up from the flesh itself. Of all these, both natural and acquired, the evil powers say there will be for us free participation and very broad enjoyment—if, having left self-control like a holy and unshaken city, we should go over to the king of Babylon, who was in the type of Satan. But Rabshakeh promised those who had gone over to the Babylonians both to release them and to grant the immediate pleasure. They were not persuaded, thinking rightly; for it will certainly follow upon wishing to choose worldly things that one must fall into involuntary slavery, and come to be in the rank of captives.

Palladius: The account is exact. But what would be the solution of these things? Explain, as you would most gladly to one asking.

Cyril: What other would there be besides that which stands opposite to how things were at first and in the beginning? For by inclinations turning away from our own wills, toward wishing to live shamefully, and pushing away the nobleness of blameless conduct, we have fallen to a base and slavish mind, thinking only earthly things, and wholly given over to fleshly pleasures. For this reason God also permitted us to slide into a reprobate mind.

Palladius: So then must we return to virtue?

Cyril: By no means negligently, O friend—for those no longer seeking life in the world—according to what was rightly spoken through Paul: “For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God.” (Colossians 3:3) Rather, thirsting for enrollment in heaven, and having made the city above as it were homeland and city, and crying out very well to God: “Deal graciously with me, for I am a sojourner on the earth, and a pilgrim, as all my fathers were.” (Psalm 118:19) For he who walks on the earth and has his citizenship glorious in heaven would truly and reasonably appear, from these very circumstances, a sojourner and pilgrim. And indeed the Savior's disciple commands us to make this our practice, and to make ourselves a manifest and comely boast, saying as follows: “Beloved, I exhort you as sojourners and pilgrims to abstain from fleshly desires, which war against the soul.” (1 Peter 2:11)

Palladius: So then would such a disposition suffice for the attainment of virtue—I mean, putting an end to fleshly lusts?

Cyril: If there were also wisely added what comes from the other forbearance—clearly the spiritual. For it is written: “Your commandment is exceedingly broad.” (Psalm 118:96) Or is not pollution in us twofold, of soul and body? I would think one must follow—and very reasonably—for those accustomed to defile, cleansing with equal balance and equal effect what is accustomed to be defiled.

Palladius: You have spoken rightly.

Cyril: Just as, then, twofold is the stain—spiritual and bodily—so also purification, spiritual and bodily, would reasonably follow. Except that for those disposed in this way—to hold to sojourning and to love life in the world—it is not unprofitable to grasp without labor, if one should choose to make Abraham an image of the matter, to whom it was said by God: “Go forth from your land and from your kindred and from your father's house. And come to the land which I will show you, and I will make you a great nation, and I will bless you and magnify your name, and you shall be blessed; and I will bless those who bless you, and those who curse you I will curse; and in you all the tribes of the earth shall be blessed.” (Genesis 12:1-3) Do you understand how he commanded him to depart not only from land and house, but also from kindred, and indeed from his father's house, and to come to the land which the one who called would show him?

Palladius: But what is this?

Cyril: Then is it not clear that when God calls to following—the spiritual following, clearly—and away from life in the world, I mean

again from life in pleasures and love of the flesh, for one wishing to slip away and honor whatever one might choose, it is quite senseless to regard anything of this sort as better? For let him reckon homeland and clan, father's house, and possession of earthly things as nothing. Therefore the Savior himself also called us to the same courage, saying: "He who loves father or mother more than me is not worthy of me; and he who loves son or daughter more than me is not worthy of me; and whoever does not take up his cross and follow after me is not worthy of me." (Matthew 10:37-38) And he adds: "And everyone who has left brothers or sisters or father or mother or wife or children or fields or houses for my name's sake will receive manifold reward and will inherit eternal life." (Matthew 19:29) Or do you not say that such bright and conspicuous courage—which counts these things as nothing—is the work of strength carried to the utmost as understood in Christ? And he makes following Christ a matter of great importance.

Palladius: Very much so indeed—for they have slipped away from the best hope and the joy in Christ: those invited to the wedding feast, but who refused to come. Of them one said, "I have married a wife, and I cannot come." And another, saying he was buying a field, was making temporary things preferable to the invitation.

Cyril: Well done, O Palladius; for you delight us by saying what is fitting, and from great quickness of learning you run ahead very well toward warmly understanding the end of the discourse. See, then, that for those who follow God wholly and in every way, having made fleshly things and worldly love of pleasure secondary to hope in him, there will certainly follow richly sharing in blessing from

above. For what does he say to Abraham? “And I will make you a great nation, and I will bless you,” (Genesis 12:2) and what is joined to these. Do you see how great a multitude of spiritual goods he heaped up for him? But in what manner he departs from the land that bore him—how is it not worth seeing? “For he took,” it says, “Sarah his wife, and Lot his brother's son, and all their possessions that they had acquired, and every soul that they had acquired in Haran. And they went forth to go into the land of Canaan; and Abraham passed through the land in its length, to the place of Shechem, to the high oak.” (Genesis 12:5) For he was departing from Haran, leaving no remnant of himself in it, but with all his kindred as it were and all his household, most eagerly transferring to the land of Canaan which God had shown. Then he goes through the land in its length, and comes to the high land. For whoever has resolved very well to follow divine ordinances, and to deem the calling from above worthy of the best care, let him go out wholly from life in worldly pleasures, and as it were with all his kindred leave no remnant of his own mind in what he once was. For he departs thus rightly and will journey through the land—for he has been called by God—that, as blessed Paul writes, he may be strengthened to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth of the mystery of Christ. (Ephesians 3:18) For then he will return well to the high land—that is, to the state re-established in virtues, having nowhere still that which was cast down toward love of the flesh. But when one has already arrived at this, what the good things will be again we shall learn from the holy Scriptures themselves: “For the Lord appeared to Abraham and said to him, ‘To your seed I will give this land.’ And

Abraham built there an altar to the Lord, who appeared to him.” (Genesis 12:7) For while still dwelling in the land of his fatherland, not yet having transferred to the holy land, only the oracle was given that he must move to another land, having spared nothing of the land that bore him. But when he came into the land of Canaan with all his household and all his possessions, and sprang up to the holy land, the grace of beholding God was given, and the security of hope in firm freedom, and the possibility henceforth to raise an altar. And for us too, then, according to the same pattern of the argument—for those who remain in the world and its most detestable pleasures there will be no grace from God; but for those called and yielding to divine laws, leaping up as to a high land toward desire and eagerness for every good thing, God grants knowledge of his own glory and promises the firm assurance of hope, and works our mind to be strong, so as already somehow to be able to offer spiritual sacrifices and become a fragrance of Christ to God and Father, according to what is written; and to present to him the body as a living sacrifice, acceptable to God—the rational and spiritual worship acceptable to God. (Romans 12:1) For he gladly receives the ways of worship in spirit, and regards the matter as spiritual sacrifice.

Palladius: One ought therefore to turn toward better things, departing from baser ones; and to welcome most gladly the calling from above, and to dwell especially in love for those honored according to Scripture—and who have obtained the best verdict from God. For if we seek to go backward and settle again on what is accustomed to wrongdoing, we shall not escape blame.

Cyril: Not so, O friend. For it is utterly grievous to choose again to be sick with the things from which one had departed; as for those once removed by God's power from worldly citizenship, it is exceedingly dangerous even merely to look back toward it, and as it were to go toward remembrance of transgressions, directing the mind toward love of them. And indeed the divine Psalmist pleads, saying: "Turn away my eyes from seeing vanity." (Psalm 118:37) For vanity is truly the distraction of this life, and the empty pleasure of temporary things, from which one ought to stand apart and depart, and to refuse even only the contemplation that is still in thoughts with pleasure—for one who has truly chosen to walk uprightly, one might easily learn even from this.

Palladius: Do you speak from that point?

Cyril: The inhabitants of Sodom, wildly driven into unnatural pleasures, dishonoring the law of intercourse which nature ordained for the procreation of children, and being incited at times toward males, and passing through what is most exceedingly aberrant, were provoking anger and as it were forcing judgment to come upon them—although the Creator is loving toward mankind. But when the time was at the doors that they must suffer, as the longsuffering toward them had been exhausted, those who would fulfill this were entering Sodom. It is written thus: "And two angels came to Sodom at evening. Lot was sitting by the gate of Sodom. And Lot saw them, and rose to meet them, and bowed with his face to the ground, and said, Behold, my lords, turn aside into your servant's house, and lodge, and wash your feet; and rising early you shall go on your way. And they said, No; but we will lodge in the square. And he

urged them strongly, and they turned aside to him, and entered his house; and he made them a feast, and baked unleavened bread for them, and they ate before they lay down.” (Genesis 19:1-3) For Lot, being of Abraham's blood, brought up in the laws of righteousness, and having cared not a little for piety toward God, sojourned in Sodom; yet among them he was an immigrant and stranger in stock and manner. “For what fellowship has light with darkness? Or what portion has a believer with an unbeliever?” (2 Corinthians 6:14) Having grown great above the local evils, and traversing the path of life customary to him, he held to holy pursuits, and honored especially the law of hospitality; sitting at the city's gates, he kindly welcomed those entering them, knowing hospitality as a God-beloved thing. When those came who would bring judgment on the unrestrainedly licentious—a pair of angels—he met them swiftly, and clearly foreshowed in his greeting the announcement of the kindness within him. For he bowed with his face to the ground, urged them to go home, and to indulge in the laws of love. But they said, No, but we will lodge in the square—signifying by this that they were strangers and without lodging, and I think provoking to more earnest zeal the one who had chosen to show hospitality, and almost cleverly hinting that he would not properly leave them homeless in the streets, cast out at crossroads. Understanding this, the righteous man pressed them more strongly, and did not treat refusal as robbery from a slack and weak mind. So he lodged them, set unleavened bread before them, and made drink. But these things the righteous man did. The Sodomites, suffering bare and shameless pleasure, impiously going around the righteous man's chamber, and falling beyond the shamelessness that had reached extremity,

demanding to be allowed to do their customary deeds; then, when they ought to have chosen hospitality, they wished to harm with unnatural lewdness. Wishing to disable Lot as he was turning them away from such wild and abominable attempts, they would perhaps have brought him into suffering itself, if the rescuers had not been present: “For the men stretched out their hands, and drew Lot in to them into the house, and shut the door of the house. And they struck the men who were at the door of the house with blindness, from least to greatest, and they wearied themselves seeking the door.” (Genesis 19:10-11) His assistance was well apportioned not in these alone. For it is written again: “And when dawn came, the angels urged Lot, saying, Rise up, take your wife and your two daughters whom you have, and go out, lest you also be destroyed with the lawlessness of the city. And they were distressed; and the angels seized his hand, and the hand of his wife, and the hands of his two daughters, the Lord having spared them.” (Genesis 19:15-16) This is a very clear example to you that we are not urged by words alone, and by admonitions to the mind to depart from sin, but that God the Savior of all comes even to this gentleness toward us, so as to make help active—according to the verse, “You have held my right hand, and by your counsel you have guided me.” (Psalm 72:24) For since human nature is not very strong, nor sufficiently able to push through away from evil, God somehow co-struggles with it toward this. And he is seen granting twofold grace: persuading by admonitions and providing help, and setting us above the evil at our feet and tyrannizing over us. You would see that this too is true—that very few are caretakers of righteousness, and great in life is the scarcity of good men; “for to find a faithful man is a work,”

according to what is written. (Proverbs 20:6) Yet such a one is chosen out, and deemed worthy of care from above not as secondary. For though he is in the world mixed with others, he suffers no harm from this, as a lily plucked from thorns, and the righteous would not perish with the wicked, according to the words of the saints.

Palladius: It has been proved, then, that by God's sparing mercy and the joint action of holy angels we shall wash away the overreaching greed that comes from baseness, and that we shall find it beyond dispute that in no way whatever shall we be caught by the punishments of the wicked—trusting in God, who has cried out clearly through one of the prophets: “I am the Lord your God, who holds your right hand, who says to you, Do not fear, Jacob, little Israel; I have helped you, says the Lord, your Redeemer, Israel.” (Isaiah 41:13-14)

Cyril: Or would not the all-powerful God show to the saints as fellow-helper that Lot was upheld by the hand of the angels? For these would be a type of God—three at the beginning approaching Abraham at the oak of Mamre, and two having come to Sodom. “For the Father judges no one,” according to the Savior's own voice, “but has given all judgment to the Son”—the Holy Spirit clearly being with him and existing naturally in him. (John 5:22)

Palladius: I understand very well. But let us survey what follows, if it seems good.

Cyril: Most readily indeed, and I will speak now. “And it came to pass,” it says, “when they had brought him outside, that they said,

Save your life; do not look behind you, nor stand in all the surrounding region; save yourself to the mountain, lest you be swept away together with them.” (Genesis 19:17) In “Save your life,” I say, it is clearly spoken: “Keep yourself pure, and do not share in others' sins.” And you will be better than worldly hindrances; for nothing at all is exchange for the soul. “For what will it profit a man, if he gain the whole world, and forfeit his own soul?” (Mark 8:36) And the command to make one's going without turning back perhaps signifies not to choose again, by turns toward baseness, to think the same as those brought under fiery judgment from intemperance (“For no one,” it says, “who has put his hand to the plow and looks back is fit for the kingdom of heaven”). (Luke 9:62) But one must hold to the way to salvation, not being dragged about here and there, and with vain imaginations of worldly desires having a light and easily scattered mind, but rather complete and sleepless, and having practiced always to look straight ahead, keeping these things in ourselves. And I will say what is still greater: for the angel says not only that one must already make the walk without turning back, but usefully added, “Do not stand in all the surrounding region. Save yourself to the mountain, lest you be swept away together with them.”

Palladius: And what would “Do not stand in all the surrounding region” wish to signify?

Cyril: This, I think—sluggishness and inactivity toward the need to flee from evil—is both dangerous and harmful.

Palladius: Explain how.

Cyril: A prophetic word said: “Woe to those who do the work of the Lord negligently. Run, that you may seize the goal.” (Jeremiah 48:10) And Paul the divine also says something of the sort somewhere. For not willing to act most vigorously and earnestly in flight from shameful things—holding inseparably to the mind's old ways, and as it were hardly departing from each baseness, but with greatest reluctance being turned toward what is by nature beneficial—would be nothing else than to stand at last in the region of wickedness, although one must depart by running. For of things possible, before going outside the limits of evil, those always about to act and rising up would be seized by judgment—before the stain is cleansed, before the pollution sunk into the soul from ancient slackness is washed away, before the charges are unloaded, and before running under the yoke of salvation—to find rest through Christ. Best of exhortations, then, is “Do not stand in all the surrounding region”—that is, in no way, having delayed, be caught in baseness; but go up rather, as to a mountain, to a life lifted up and conspicuous, having nothing cast down to earth, but shining forth in high and lifted-up virtue, and freed from the most lowly mindset—that is, the earthly and fleshly. For it is written that “God's mighty ones of the earth were greatly lifted up.” (Psalm 47:9) For above earthly things is the holiness-befitting mindset. “And the young vultures fly on high,” according to what is written, (Job 39:27) if they have their citizenship as on a mountain in heaven, and make the homeland above their own. Paul also writes somewhere: “Seek the things above, not the things on earth.” (Colossians 3:2)

Palladius: A mountain, then, is the spiritual one—the life in holiness, and the elevated height of exceptional citizenship—with

what is understood as below being the life in impurity and love of sin, welded to earthly things.

Cyril: You have spoken well; for the argument very clearly shows this to us, and you would wonder at this too.

Palladius: What is that?

Cyril: For the blessed angel, as Lot the divine was running negligently and without turning back, was saying that he must leap up to the mountain. He was pleading, saying: “I entreat you, Lord, since your servant has found mercy before you, and you have magnified your righteousness in sparing my soul; I cannot be saved on the mountain—lest the evils overtake me and I die. Behold, this city is near for me to flee there; it is small, and there I shall be saved. Is it not a little one, and my soul will live?” And speaking to him, it says: “Behold, I have granted your request, even in this matter, not to overthrow the city of which you have spoken. Hurry, then, to be saved there; for I cannot do anything until you have entered there.” Therefore the name of that city was called Zoar. The sun went forth upon the earth, and Lot entered Zoar. (Genesis 19:18-23)

Palladius: And what benefit would there also be for us from these things? I would wish, as you know well, to learn thoroughly.

Cyril: Or do you not understand—though you have greatly inclined toward being very quick to learn—that for those who have just run out from baseness, yet think they must go toward the path of salvation, virtue is not immediately, nor from first attempts, attainable and secure? Nor would one easily be brought back to a lifted-up way of life, nor would one soon be far from passions

somehow reared together with oneself; but one will be outside such things gently—at least as to eagerness for better things and beginnings of attempts—not very high, or far, but would almost transfer to another land as it were, to a life indeed praised, but not yet having received glory high and conspicuous—such as was the pedagogy according to law, referring to beginnings of life both best and good. For it is written: “The beginning of a good way is to do just things.” For just as for those zealous for knowledge and desiring mystical contemplation, the discourse of catechism would be suitable at the beginning and especially fitting, but they hasten toward a man already perfect and to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ, (Ephesians 4:13) the more solid food would already somehow be fitting—that is, discourse about the highest things, and every path thereafter of dogmatic inquiry; so also here I say—in corrections of character and conduct—it would not be among possible things for some to leap at once to the blameless state, that is, to superhuman and haughty citizenship. It would be fitting, I think, gradually, according to one's present condition, beginning from small and proportionate things, and almost running ahead as to a small city neighbor to a high mountain—the citizenship that sits under and is lesser than the exceptional and heavenly life. Thus righteous Lot would be a type of those disposed this way—not to the mountain straightway, but deeming fit to lodge in little Zoar. For do we not often find such economies in gospel preaching among believers? Blessed Paul also writes, saying: “It is good for a man not to touch a woman; but because of fornications let each man have his own wife, and let each woman have her own husband. This I say by way of concession, not command. For I wish

all men to be even as I myself. But each has his own gift from God, one in this way, and another in that.” (1 Corinthians 7:1-7) You see how the extreme of self-control, as a mountain, he showed us, saying, “It is good for a man not to touch a woman;” but he permitted us to lodge in Zoar—that is, in the conduct still beneath that of the perfect, I mean the being allowed to be joined only with one's own wife. The Savior said the best land would yield fruits—one a hundredfold, one sixty, one thirty; (Matthew 13:8) and he distributed the talent not in equal measure, but to one five, to another two, to another one—showing, I think, by these things the unequal strength of dispositions, and distributing to each according as he has fitness and mind. For as we said just now, “Each has his own gift from God, one in this way, and another in that.”

Palladius: You speak well.

Cyril: The blessed angel permits lodging in Zoar. “Behold,” he says, “I have granted your request, even in this matter, not to overthrow the city of which you have spoken. Hurry, then, to be saved there.” Then it says that “the sun went forth upon the earth, and Lot entered Zoar.” (Genesis 19:21-23) You would wonder, O friend, what the mind might be in learning these things too: “For I have granted your request,” it says, “not to overthrow the city of which you have spoken.” For unwilling by God, truly, is citizenship not fully disposed toward virtue, and to be defeated somehow by passions is rejected by him and not far from condemnation. Yet he permits it out of love for mankind, and having measured to nature what is attainable at the beginning, he commands them to be saved while still practicing the good, and not yet wholly traversing blameless

conduct. But even for those who come to this measure and enter into this state, the entrance would not be without divine light and torch-bearing from above. “For the sun rose,” it says, “and Lot entered Zoar.”

Palladius: How very fittingly you have spoken!

Cyril: So the divine Lot entered the still small city, God permitting him; and weak was proved in this respect also the woman who followed and fled with him. “For she looked back,” it says, “and became a pillar of salt.” (Genesis 19:26) See that the manly mind and youthful disposition—even if perhaps not arriving fully at what pleases God, having begun to accomplish virtue—nevertheless makes states of passion gradually toward the better condition. But the weak and unmanly, whose sign is the woman, is rendered utterly useless by turns toward baseness. For this, I think, becoming a pillar of salt signifies—which would be a symbol of withered mind, and mind set to pass into senselessness, and driven already somehow into ultimate insensibility. When salt has lost its savor, it is good for nothing further, the Savior himself said; (Matthew 5:13) it will be utterly useless, cast out and trampled under men's feet. So the woman was turned to stone, but Lot did not long delay over what remained. For it is written that “Lot went up out of Zoar and dwelt on the mountain, he and his two daughters with him; for they were afraid to dwell in Zoar, and they dwelt in a cave, he and his two daughters with him.” (Genesis 19:30) For the mind proceeds as by steps to what it presently holds, and leaps up little by little toward what it was at the beginning—not being suitably disposed nor very sufficiently. It proceeds and returns upward toward the better,

entrusting itself to spiritual wisdom and courage as to its own daughters, and leaving below to remain the pleasure-soft and unmanly things, of which the woman is the type. He dwells finally as on mountain and in cave—the mountain signifying for us what is high and lifted for spiritual fitness, and the cave very well signifying what is fixed and steadfast in perseverance in virtue. For it is written thus concerning good men: “Walking in righteousness, speaking a straight path, hating lawlessness and injustice, and shaking off his hands from bribes, stopping his ears that he may not hear judgment of blood, closing his eyes that he may not see injustice—this one shall dwell in a high cave of strong rock.” (Isaiah 33:15-16) And otherwise our discourse on this point would not be implausible. For Christ is the Rock, because of the strength and invulnerability of the highest of all essences; and the Church in Christ may be understood as the cave—the lodging of the saints, the shelter of the pious, in which the righteous dwell, and those who shun judgment by fire.

Palladius: How well, O friend, the discourse holds for us! I would wish also to go through the exercise by as many other proofs as we have. For to love learning richly what leads to benefit, I would judge altogether worthy.

Cyril: And indeed, O Palladius, you speak what is fitting. For it would be the fruit of a mind most eager to learn, and our discourse will be better than sloth—not the same, in my view, as such bright and worthy narratives, allowing untimely silence to intrude. Therefore one must wholly and in every way withdraw from disposition and fellowship toward base things, as opportunity allows; and indeed ability to be reared up toward virtue would come

about in no other way than in this very manner—we shall consider without labor, fixing the eye of the mind very well, both on those according to the divine Abraham, and on those accomplished beyond speech in the exodus of those from Israel, which they made at the time of Egyptian greed, having broken the bonds.

Palladius: Explain then section by section—as you know well, delighting us richly, if you should choose to do this.

Cyril: We say then that once, pressed down by unbearable famine and lack of necessities, the divine Abraham did not willingly make the descent into Egypt, but yielded to necessities. Pharaoh was occupied with griefs and covetousness toward him as stranger and immigrant; for he wanted to take away his wife, burned with intemperate pleasures, toward shameful acts. God did not allow him to accomplish this. “For,” it says, “he afflicted Pharaoh with great punishments concerning Sarah, Abraham's wife.” (Genesis 12:17) Pharaoh is also an image and type of diabolical intemperance. For his aim, and of those most zealous for him, is to inject into the minds of the saints the seeds of the impurity within him, that they might choose to bear fruit pleasing to him and according to pleasure. These would be, I think, the charges leading to manifold sin. And everyone would be caught and unwillingly subject to his covetousness. For nature is sick with weakness; yet God does not permit it, somehow reining in attempts against the saints and the evil one's plots. It happened that the divine Abraham escaped harm in no other way than leaving Egypt and returning to the place from the beginning given by God, where arriving he was at leisure overseer of good pursuits. It is written thus: “And Abraham went up out of Egypt, he

and his wife and all that he had, and Lot with him, into the wilderness. Abraham was very rich in cattle and silver and gold, and he went wherever he had gone into the wilderness, as far as Bethel, to the place where his tent had been at the beginning, between Bethel and Hai, to the place of the altar which he had made there at the beginning. And Abram called on the name of the Lord there.” (Genesis 13:1-4) Do you understand that they must depart together with all their possessions—those returning from worldly intemperance to another sacred life? For with all household and all kindred—and I would add all possessions—the forefather Abraham fled the land of Egypt. One must wholly depart and as it were with whole household turn toward the wilderness—that is, toward an undisturbed and pure state of mind, from which human nature also fell away in the beginning, turning from lack of goods from above toward worse things. For the descent to foreigners would enigmatically signify this—from the land and tent of the beginning and most beloved, in which also was the altar. Returning thus, until we come to the place and region of the altar from the beginning—that is, of anciently attached sanctification—we call upon the God of all, speaking that prophetic address: “Lord, besides you we know no other. We name your name.” (Isaiah 26:13)

Palladius: You have spoken most excellently.

Cyril: You would see that the matter holds for us in no other way, if you examine well the events that happened to the children of Israel in due season; whom, since the Egyptians had taken them when famine pressed down at the beginning—both those from above and from holy root, binding free men to unexpected and unpracticed

servitude—they pressed harshly, contriving such an occasion for cruelty against them. “For,” it says, “another king arose over Egypt, who did not know Joseph. And he said to his people: Behold, the race of the children of Israel is a great multitude and is stronger than we; come, let us deal wisely with them, lest they multiply, and when war happens, they also join our adversaries and fight against us and go out from the land.” (Exodus 1:8-10) For it grieved, I think, the ruler of the land of Egypt even to see them choose freedom at some point—those yoked from necessary bondage, not by choice. “And he set over them,” it says, “taskmasters of the works, to afflict them in their works, and they built for Pharaoh fortified cities, Pithom and Rameses and On, which is Heliopolis.” (Exodus 1:11) For they were fruits of unbearable covetousness—enduring sufferings in clay and brick, but cities walled with towers and embankments raised in the fields—and these things were accomplished without pay and with long sweat for those laboring. For the world-rulers of this age, having taken into their own hand the wretched souls of men, crush them with clay and bricks and with things done on earth and about earth, and having bound them to evil and unprofitable temptation (for such appear to be the works of the flesh and those about it), they bitterly compel acceptance of a thoroughly wretched life, which in no way brings benefit to those forced to pursue it. For what would the works and passions of the flesh benefit our wretched soul? Profit, as it were, is reckoned from us to the devil and demons, and the wealth of the opposing kingdom will be boast and glory—as, for example, Pharaoh too thought it no small glory to build cities for himself, with those from Israel compelled to come to this without food and without pay.

Palladius: It is so. For the argument is very clear.

Cyril: The toil of the Israelites records, then, a representation and as it were a clear image of the random and unholy pursuits on our earth—Satan himself lying in wait and trampling upon them, and the evil powers with him, whom divine Scripture signifies by the names of taskmasters; the evil distraction, I would say, is full of sweat and toil, yet filled as with clay and impurity and muddy pleasure. But God had mercy even then on those most impious and most savagely afflicted by Egyptian covetousness, and serving even beyond what was due. For he immediately made Moses, most excellent, minister of kindness toward them. Or shall we not find God doing this also toward us? For when we had slipped into sins, he grants mercy and immediately instills his own law in all hearts, as mediator, as it were, leading to free life.

Palladius: I understand what you say.

Cyril: Do you wish, then, cutting short the breadth of history, to speak fittingly as we can?

Palladius: By all means.

Cyril: It is written thus: “And afterward Moses and Aaron went in to Pharaoh and said to him: Thus says the Lord God of Israel: Send away my people, that they may hold a feast to me in the wilderness. And Pharaoh said: Who is he, that I should listen to his voice to send away the children of Israel? I do not know the Lord, and I will not send Israel away.” (Exodus 5:1-2) For Moses and Aaron were assuring Israel that they must depart from the region and land of Egypt, God calling to a feast; for a feast truly real is to be freed from

the yoke of slavery unwilling by God, and thereafter to be under God and fulfill what pleases him, with no one opposing—that is, to choose and love what he wills and compels. Pharaoh speaks very harshly and is insolent toward God's glory, saying he knows not the Lord and will not release Israel. The divine Moses does not cease at all, but strongly insists that what God wills must be accomplished. For when Satan is being led out to freedom, those who have been under him must grow courageous and become better in every way, I think, without hindrance, and least of all appear cowardly, but be bold, saying: “The God of the Hebrews has called us. We will go a journey of three days into the wilderness, that we may sacrifice to our God, lest death or murder meet us.” (Exodus 5:3) For this the wise Moses then cried out to us. “Not by likeness to you, O Egyptians,” he says, “is a calf our worship as Hebrews, nor pig, nor goat, nor image of a man, nor shadow of birds, nor images of reptiles established in shrines. The God and Master who framed all this has called us. Great, then, is the God of the Hebrews—incomparable even to Egyptians and above all creation—who calls us into the wilderness to bring there the sacrifice pleasing to him. Egypt is called darkness; and I think we who are spiritual must apply ourselves to what is in shadow and types. For we, departing very far from everything accustomed to darken, and as it were having left a country lying under the tyrant—I mean Satan—with its ease in sins, must hasten youthfully to a more relaxed and purer life and walk the path of lawful conduct not subject to demons; then we shall be able to offer the fruits of righteousness to God.” He assured that those from Israel must set out a journey of three days through the wilderness, declaring by this

that they must not be near the borders of baseness and the life tyrannized by it. The divine Moses also devises something wise, saying very aptly that those called by God must withdraw from Egypt: “Lest,” he says, “death or murder meet us.”

Palladius: And what is this? For it is not ready for those who wish to understand.

Cyril: I will explain: among Egyptians it was custom—and it is still observed among idol-worshippers—to require, when entering temples, that one refuse encounter with a dead body. They say the highest pollution is not only to touch, if one should choose, but even to fall upon such sights in passing glances. Therefore from their customs he persuades them to think sacrifice cannot be made purely for them if, when they have begun to do this unexpectedly, they should meet death or murder—that is, one dead by law of nature, or forced out by murderers. “You have,” he was saying, “shrines and precincts, bolts and gates; within which, if you have run in, you may sacrifice purely, as you suppose for yourselves; but we must sacrifice in the midst of the city, at crossroads and in fields, defiled by sights of the dead.” For what hinders by borders—nothing at all. The argument of history may have plausibility for us as in Egyptian customs; yet what Moses the all-wise said would be rightly spoken even if understood spiritually. We must sacrifice as in wilderness and accomplish holy feast to God, departing from Egypt and refusing even sight of death. With mind at leisure and standing far from worldly darkening, and freeing the eye from things leading to deadness and corruption, we shall sacrifice purely to God who holds all things. Dead works would be those of the flesh; worldly

darkness—the clouding from evil and random distractions—pollutes the pure and transparent air of the mind. That those who wish to worship sincerely must withdraw from these things, the argument of history also persuades us.

Palladius: And indeed this is not unclear; pass on to me, then, what follows.

Cyril: A grievous and sharp longing for ancient freedom, I think, entered those from Israel; but already turned toward this, Pharaoh terribly provoked to anger the one yoked under slavery's yokes. Calling their desires on such matters a work of leisure, he orders sweat upon works to be redoubled for them, the customary quota demanded without delay, and distribution of straw unusually cut off for them; for he said: “You are at leisure, you are idlers; therefore you say, Let us go and sacrifice to our God. Now therefore go and work; for straw will not be given you, and you shall give the quota of bricks yourselves.” (Exodus 5:17-18) The scribes of the children of Israel found themselves in evil, saying: “You will not diminish the daily portion of bricks.” (Exodus 5:19) Moses and Aaron met them coming to meet them as they came out from Pharaoh, and they said to them: “May God look upon you and judge, because you have made our odor abhorred before Pharaoh and before his servants, putting a sword in their hands to kill us.” (Exodus 5:20-21) Or do you not say, O friend, it is exact that whenever one chooses to cast off the yoke of the devil's covetousness and take up again the bright and free boast of worship toward God, one should have leisure and know the true Master, according to what is hymned in the Psalms: “Have leisure and know that I am the Lord God” (Psalm 45:11)—he

will charge us as an impious matter this leisure and will on the matter, while the enemy of all sets himself against us together with other evil and unclean spirits, wildly forcing adherence to carnal and earthly impurity and endless clinging to worldly things according to each one's custom, but least of all permitting abstinence from habitual baseness, and making even this hard to obtain, so that evil may not be spat upon by one very ready and go to satiety? These things, I think, signify demanding vigorously the quota of bricks, but depriving of what would make it easy—namely straw. We are somehow constituted, then, most eagerly and vigorously to seek customary things and burn with hotter desires for them when something in between appears, as from necessity, leading to inability to obtain them. When divine law re-educates the human mind with baser things, a long desire penetrates then especially, calling toward the same things and almost persuading to cry out against the lawgiver; and again, as demonstration in shadows, the scribes of the children of Israel, consumed in works and not seeing the easy path to them—for they were in want of straw—greatly blamed Moses and Aaron for the cause brought upon them, saying they had become a pretext and endured a harder onset of covetousness, for no other reason than that only desire for freedom had entered them, persuaded by their words.

Palladius: Do you not think one should speak what is fitting and true?

Cyril: Entirely so, O Palladius; for whenever good desire and good reasoning have startled us perhaps toward choosing what pleases God, and we have remembered the law for piety, the enemy of all

rushes most wickedly to harm—yet God hides and saves. And he said to Moses: “Go, speak to the children of Israel, saying: I am the Lord, and I will bring you out from the dominion of the Egyptians, and I will deliver you from their bondage, and I will redeem you with outstretched arm and great judgment, and I will take you to myself as a people. And I will be your God, and you will know that I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt from the dominion of the Egyptians.” (Exodus 6:6-7) For when Satan turns us away and raises up every good desire and pushes us by whatever means he can toward this, God's law urges good will, showing the helper unbreakable, exhorting by most importunate hope to courage, strengthening by faith, and assigning to God as true savior and redeemer.

Palladius: How excellent a matter faith is, and salvific—and to thirst to follow God!

Cyril: You have spoken rightly. Faith creeps toward the good at the end—you will know well—as our argument completes its own purpose. For when Moses and Aaron came again to Pharaoh to persuade him to release from Egypt and free Israel from ancient bonds, they wished to shame him by signs beyond reason, showing rod changed to serpent, and promising very readily to accomplish still greater and surpassing things through God clearly. He ordered his own magicians to work equally, crying as it were: “We are not ignorant of such works. There are very many more among Egyptians than with you; miracle-working is study for magicians, of whom you too are numbered.” But when he was very hardened and did not release Israel, four terrible plagues, each worse than the other, were

brought—water strangely changed to blood, frogs and gnats, and lastly dog-fly, which somehow more softly, as from unbearable necessity, made Pharaoh yield. Calling Moses and Aaron, he says: “Go in and sacrifice to the Lord your God in the land.” And Moses said: “It is not possible to do thus; for we shall sacrifice the abominations of the Egyptians to the Lord our God. If we sacrifice the abominations of the Egyptians before them, we shall be stoned. We will journey three days into the wilderness and sacrifice to the Lord our God, as he said to us.” And Pharaoh said: “I will send you away, and you shall sacrifice to the Lord your God in the wilderness—only you shall not extend far in going.” (Exodus 8:25-28) For when Satan withstands us and youthfully knows to oppose our good intentions with his own mischief-making, God resists and restrains the bold and chastens with plagues. Then he hardly yields, not willingly; yet he still tries to persuade us to make worship toward God inexact, yet not altogether to depart from slavery to him. For he ordered Jews to sacrifice not outside their own land but in it. Most wisely Moses said: “It is not possible to do thus.” For the inventor of sin is always advocate of base things; divine law sends these forth and forbids doing what seems good to him. Care is required, then, for those wishing to live rightly—not to what the Evil One says deceitfully, but to what divine oracle proclaims to us: “For your law is a lamp to my feet and light to my paths.” (Psalm 118:105)

Palladius: True.

Cyril: While the Evil One holds us—that is, wishes to confine and keep us under himself—we must worship God alone by nature, and

standing far from double-mindedness as from poison, say: “It is not possible to do thus.”—“For no one can serve two masters; for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will hold to one and despise the other.” (Matthew 6:24) It is also written: “Woe to faint hearts, to hands grown weak, and to a sinner walking on two paths!” (Sirach 2:14) One must, I say, make worship pure and blameless to God who holds all things, having wholly departed from slavery under that one, and thus seek the better life nobly; otherwise: “We shall sacrifice the abominations of the Egyptians to the Lord our God; for if we sacrifice the abominations of the Egyptians before them, we shall be stoned.” As far as the argument of history goes, the refusal is plausible. For he calls objects of veneration here abominations; calves were the Egyptians' worship. “If we sacrifice these to the God of the Hebrews,” he says, “we shall sharpen all Egypt to anger, making a grievous matter of it.” Sometimes the argument is plausible. As far as spiritual contemplation goes, the benefit is not moderate. For the multitude of demons—which he knows especially how to honor and makes much of and deems worthy of all speech—by our slaying them we accomplish sweetest worship to God.

Palladius: How did you say?

Cyril: Are not the passions of the flesh honorable in themselves? And not at all for themselves—but indeed through them we perish, and are bound to slavery under them?

Palladius: True.

Cyril: Slaughtering these, then, and as it were putting them to death, we shall be fragrance of sweet odor to God. Paul writes thus: “Present your bodies a living sacrifice, acceptable to God, your reasonable worship.” (Romans 12:1) One would rightly do this by deadening members on earth: fornication, impurity, passion, evil desire, and covetousness. (Colossians 3:5) Each passion in us, then, is abomination of spiritual Egyptians—that is, most venerable. For since divine Scripture is accustomed to call what stands in idol's rank abomination, and as it were some object of veneration, God persuades by Jeremiah's voice concerning the Jewish synagogue: “What has my beloved done abomination in my house?” (Jeremiah 11:15) If one wished to call abomination of Egyptians what is as it were hatred and rejection, he would not depart from fitting mind; for what unclean spirits are always accustomed to hate and abhor, these are set forth by us as fragrance of sweet odor to God and spiritual sacrifice—faith, gentleness, self-control, sobriety, brotherly love, and boasts of sincerity toward God.

Palladius: And who would be those sacrificing in the land to the Evil One? Would some also be understood outside the land?

Cyril: Those not yet having departed Egypt and sacrificing to God in it are very many, perhaps better than number; but those outside and in wilderness are altogether few and chosen: “For many are called,” he says, “but few are chosen.” (Matthew 22:14) We are all called to freedom through faith in Christ and redeemed from diabolical tyranny, Christ bringing us to this—prefigured of old well in Moses and Aaron, that in the same person you may understand Emmanuel as lawgiver and high priest and apostle in economic sense. Yet most

of those called still linger in ancient evils, not yet having departed wholly in understanding from worldly deceit, as if they worship God in naked faith alone. These we say are those sacrificing in Egypt—that is, having gone out only a little. “You shall not extend far in going,” says hard-hearted Pharaoh, “even if you run out from Egypt's land.” But those wishing to please God with whole transformation to good, freed altogether from worldly confusion, are carried outside Egypt and escape the tyrant's hand; and as in wilderness, in leisurely and relaxed life, they sacrifice purely to God. I would also say in another way that those running from worshiping creature rather than Creator to truth and to knowledge of God according to nature must be carried far from Egypt's land. For they have not yet perfectly rubbed away remnants of ancient deceit from their own understanding. Certain ones observe days and months and seasons and years. These, called to free dignity through Christ while dwelling in Egypt's house, still sacrifice to God, preserving life not unwelcome to Satan. But if one departs altogether, having bid farewell to the older customs, he sacrifices in wilderness and pursues life worthy of all praise.

Palladius: I agree; for you understand correctly. But let the argument proceed again for us in due course.

Cyril: Therefore Pharaoh speaks falsely and denies his promise, but does not yet release those from Israel. Then he was afflicted with three other plagues, and barely consents, saying he will release them—and he was caught false-promising again. “For he is a liar, and does not stand in the truth,” (John 8:44) according to the Savior's voice. God threatens and sends upon the Egyptians the most

violent hail, and indeed sends it, and moreover locust the field-destroyer—if one must also borrow a word from Greek to say it. Then at last the once fierce and unbreakable defenders of Pharaoh's abomination raise the greatest outcry against him, saying: “How long shall this be a snag for us? Send the people away, that they may worship the Lord their God. Or do you wish to know that Egypt is destroyed?” (Exodus 10:7) And again from this I am persuaded to understand that Satan is perhaps superior to the powers under him, on whom it befits him to prevail. For they, as it seems, are very hard and utterly merciless, and late and barely would come even to moderate perception of divine wrath; but he is excessive in savagery beyond reason and has grown hard to the extreme. For it is written: “His heart has been fixed like stone, and stands like an anvil unmoved.” (Exodus 9:35) When outcry against him became very great, he said with difficulty to Moses and Aaron: “Go and worship the Lord your God. But who are those who are going?” And Moses says: “We will go with our young men and our elders, with our sons and daughters, with our flocks and our herds; for it is the feast of the Lord our God.” And he said to them: “May the Lord be with you, as I send you away—only not with your baggage too? See, mischief is before you. Not so; let the men go and worship God, for that is what you seek.” (Exodus 10:8-11) Understand then, O friend, that Moses said the departure must be made in the best way; but Pharaoh says not so: he would release only in part, and as it were demanded hostages through the return of those departing, with baggage remaining behind in Egypt. “Let every young man of yours go,” he says, “and every kind in its prime.” But divine Moses strongly insists that departure must be made, omitting nothing—together

those in youth and in decline of age, sons and daughters, herds of cattle, and other livestock. For those striving to be transformed to true freedom must be altogether freed from evils in the world and walk the path of virtues, leaving no remnant at all of soul or mind by which they might again be subjected to the evil one's covetousness. To this divine law calls young men and virgins, elders with younger ones, according to the Psalmist's voice, and every kind of age understood in Christ. To these the divine John also speaks, saying: "I write to you, children, because you have known the Father; I write to you, fathers, because you have known him who is from the beginning; I write to you, young men, because you are strong, and the word of God abides in you, and you have overcome the evil one." (1 John 2:12-14) It could also be put otherwise: young men are type of courage, elders of wisdom, and childhood understood in Christ—sons and daughters; for with courage, wisdom, and godly simplicity we depart from sin into sanctification. "Be courageous," he says, "and let your heart be strong." (Psalm 27:14) And again: "Be wise as serpents and innocent as doves." (Matthew 10:16) By saying sheep and oxen run off together, I think he signifies that one must not leave to Satan even the bodily and more irrational movements within us. And the divine Paul writes: "For just as you presented your members slaves to impurity and to lawlessness leading to lawlessness, so now present your members slaves to righteousness leading to sanctification." (Romans 6:19)

Palladius: See then—he releases those in youth and in their prime, but Pharaoh keeps back the rest?

Cyril: What do you say those remaining in Egypt are?

Palladius: There were, I think, certainly women, underage children, and weak elders, and irrational livestock.

Cyril: Come then, O best, how do you not immediately understand that?

Palladius: What do you mean?

Cyril: For he considers burdensome those who are spirited and young and have a more vigorous disposition toward piety; for he wants to be rid of, I think, and not willingly, those who have stood against him—who are also able to resist and to defend themselves when wronged—according to the word: “Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.” (James 4:7) But he keeps back very much those not accustomed to act manfully, and as an inactive and unwarlike sort he loves, diseased in himself, the female and soft mind-set, and what is as it were past youth and weak, still somewhat adolescent, and the dense and more irrational—as in the type of oxen and sheep.

Palladius: You have spoken well.

Cyril: Again Pharaoh speaks falsely, hard-minded and inflexible. Then, when their whole country was being consumed, so to speak, by the locust assaults, he sends for Moses, Aaron coming in with him, and says: “Go and worship the Lord your God; only leave your flocks and herds behind, and let your baggage go with you.” (Exodus 10:24) And Moses said: “But you also shall give us whole burnt offerings and sacrifices, which we shall offer to the Lord our God; and our cattle shall go with us, and we shall not leave behind a hoof; for from them we must take what is needed to serve the Lord our God.” (Exodus 10:25-26)

Palladius: And to which of the things said by the all-wise Moses shall we apply our understanding? Or how might one take what is from Egypt and Pharaoh and offer it to God?

Cyril: And indeed, O companion, the argument is clear. For the one opposing and fighting those who wish to be pious, if it were not entirely permitted that some lie under him, would desire at least in part to have this; but God's law teaches departure with utmost sharpness, not permitting in any way to lie and remain under him—not a particle of soul, not of mind, not occasion of bodily movement. Moreover one must bring to God the fairest and choicest things of life in the world. This, I think, signifies taking from Egypt and offering to God. Is it not that those who through worldly wisdom contend with our holy and divine doctrines, hunting the bright in wording and the bitter in knowledge, and performing rational worship to God, do this? “For all wisdom is from the Lord,” as it is written. (Sirach 1:1) But in worldly spirit we say Greek poets and prose writers arrived at this splendor of eloquence. And the divine Paul: “We have not received the spirit of this world, but the Spirit from God, that we might know the things freely given us by God; which also we speak, not in words taught by human wisdom, but in demonstration of the Spirit.” (1 Corinthians 2:12-13) That Moses was still truly in shadows—saying the choicest things of worldly life would not be rejected by God according to nature—he immediately shows plainly, but as in type and shadow. For God commanding to plunder the Egyptians, Moses said they must use gold and silver vessels, from tent-mate and neighbor—accomplished even through women. (Exodus 3:22) For such an affair is always rather secretive—full of gossip and ingenious for deception. The

gold and silver vessels from Egyptians would be, as I just said, what worldly people would fittingly use to adorn themselves—even if they had known the true God. What I say is again somewhat as follows. Common to all humans are movements of mind and soul, and suitability toward anything good or evil. Those who have used nature's advantages well achieve noble and excellent life; but those who most foolishly turn aside to what is unfitting somehow mark nature's goods and the path to shameful things. For courage and prudence are good for those who use them best, but harmful for those who do not hold them rightly; one may be courageous and prudent with praise and applause, and one may possess them amid much outcry against. These things are common in all—both those still wandering and those who know God. When courage that once worked baseness, and bitter shrewdness, are transformed by us into what pleases God, things taken as it were from Egyptians and from worldly life become holy and acceptable to God; for they are reconfigured into virtue's use and ministry of sanctification—just as gold and silver vessels from Egypt proved useful for construction and completion of the holy tabernacle. After plundering the Egyptians and the death of the firstborn, those from Israel were barely redeemed, having sacrificed the lamb as type of Christ; for they could not obtain this otherwise, since all redemption is in Christ and through him every good gift. They are sent out from Egypt at midnight, as it were freed together from darkness and slavery. For slavery to sin loves always to exist in intellectual darkness, not in divine light. “For everyone who practices evil hates the light,” (John 3:20) according to the Savior's voice. Their dough is carried out unleavened, and they flee without provisions. “For the Egyptians

were pressing the people, hastening to drive them from the land; for they said, ‘We are all dying.’ And the people took up their dough before it was leavened, their kneading-bowls bound up in their garments on their shoulders.” (Exodus 12:33-34) For I think those about to cleave to God, having chosen kinship with him, must not carry remnant of worldly evil, nor provision themselves with alien and unholy foods—spiritual ones, clearly; they must love to be unleavened, no longer desiring what gives life to the world. Such ones would celebrate purely and, accomplishing worship worthy of God, remain under him forever.

Palladius: It is settled, then, that just as one must attain to a holy and sacred land, those who are God-loving and good must attain to life under Christ and free from tyranny; yet they must hasten to sacrifice not in the enemies' manner—that is, not being in a sin-loving state, nor quite blameless, but rather in eagerness toward virtue and in moral disposition exiled from the devil's tyranny.

Cyril: You would suppose it holds no other way than this, O sir; for our discourse has been rightly composed. But if it seems good, consider this also through another image. For when, through flight to every foreign place, those dwelling the holy city—I mean Jerusalem—no longer dared to grieve the Savior God of all, they came under the Babylonians, who took spear-won captives and ordered them to serve. Yielding was necessary to those ruling, not willingly. Those in extreme grief, wailing at unexpected disasters, would sometimes seek brief relief from pain. This was to soften the sharpness of their grief through hymns to God: “For I remembered God and was glad,” (Psalm 76:4) the divine David said, declaring

spiritual feast—the hymn to God. Yet it seemed somehow shameful to those wishing to sing and fulfill customary rites to pour such sweet sound into foreigners' ears, and as it were cast into the air their dearest and clearest melody—Babylonians sometimes mocking and altogether annoyed at songs with instruments. Therefore they said: “By the rivers of Babylon there we sat and wept, when we remembered Zion”—in which, according to Jewish laws and customs, the sacrifice of praise was brought with strings and instruments, accomplished and enchanting with its strains those approaching the divine temple. But since they were bound in foreign slavery's yoke, lamenting they say: “On the willows in her midst we hung our instruments”—signifying by this very thing inactivity in songs. For the willow is fruitless, or rather a harmful-fruit plant, as Greek poets have said. Song's instruments were set to idleness and fruitlessness; and the lamenters cried out the occasion for this ease, saying: “How shall we sing the Lord's song on a foreign land?” (Psalm 136:1-4) When Baruch delivered Jeremiah's words to them: “All wept,” it says, “and fasted and prayed prayer before the Lord; and they gathered silver, as each one's hand was able; and they sent to Jerusalem to Joiakim son of Hilkiah son of Shallum the priest, and to the priests and to all the people found with him in Jerusalem.” (Baruch 1:5-7) And after other things: “And they said: Behold we have sent you silver; buy with the silver burnt offerings and sin offerings and frankincense, and make a grain offering, and bring it up on the altar of the Lord our God.” (Baruch 1:10) For they thought it fitting for themselves, exiled from holy land, no longer to sacrifice—acting no longer under God, but as if yoked to another and fallen under tyrannical hand—yet to assign worship to those still

dwelling the holy city and having received sacred ministry's glory, using right reasoning toward provision of what is fitting and necessary. And wise Daniel himself, devoted to sacred pursuits while captive with the others, managed cleverly the matter of necessity. And in what way, I shall say: for he prayed three times of the day. Windows in his upper chamber looked and were opened toward Jerusalem. It is written thus: he thought his own prayer would then hardly be acceptable to God—from a foreign and hated land—if flesh could not be there, yet at least in thoughts he would withdraw, and with mind's eyes look toward God's most beloved land, and as if having entered the temple itself, offer petition for what he would choose.

Palladius: Well indeed—truly the whole discourse has been fitted together for us.